

We Found 3 Leaks Costing You ~40% of Ad Spend

6

/ 10 HOT

Prepared by Smart Pursuit - Performance Marketing for Scaling D2C & Edtech Brands

90+

Active Meta ads

Rs.2-4 Cr

Est. monthly spend

**Edtech / Test
Prep (JEE, NEET,
UPSC, CAT)**

Niche

Rs.826 Cr FY25

Revenue

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Unacademy (unacademy.com) is one of India's largest test-prep platforms and was acquired by upGrad in a deal that closed September 1, 2026 (~\$206M, roughly 94% below its \$3.44B 2021 peak). We identified ~90 active Meta creatives running across India (JEE, NEET, UPSC, CAT, GATE, Bank/SSC, plus the Airlearn language app). Estimated spend is **Rs.2-4 Cr/mo** - a shadow of pre-2022 levels after marketing was cut ~70%, but still a material budget. FY25 revenue was **Rs.826 Cr (down 16.4% YoY)** against a net loss of Rs.435 Cr.

The funnel leaks at three obvious points: (1) Creative: ads are influencer/educator talking-head heavy with very little topper/result UGC or parent-testimonial variety - the exact gap its listed rival Physics Wallah exploits. (2) Landing page: paid traffic lands on a generic brand homepage ("Crack your goal with India's top educators") with no course-specific page, no topper reviews above the fold, and a phone-OTP-only signup gate that adds friction. (3) Tracking: the site is a Next.js SPA; pixel/CAPI is not verifiable on first paint and, post-merger, Unacademy and upGrad tags will need consolidation to avoid double-counting.

These are **fixable in 7 days**. Realistic caution: this is an enterprise lead in active integration and cost-cutting mode, so closability is moderate - pitch efficiency and post-merger consolidation, not 'spend more'. WARM lead.

1. AD INTELLIGENCE

Active platforms	Meta (Facebook + Instagram) primary; YouTube (Shorts + long-form) for class previews; Google Search for brand + exam terms; app-install campaigns for the Unacademy learner app and Airlearn.
Active ads count	~90 live creatives across JEE, NEET, UPSC, CAT, GATE, Bank/SSC and Airlearn language learning (Ad Library, country=IN).
Duration signals	Several evergreen 'Join for free' / batch-launch creatives running 30+ days - winners, but high fatigue risk and a thin refresh cadence.
Funnel type	Website traffic to subscription signup (primary); app install (learner app + Airlearn) secondary; lead-form for free live classes / test series.
Budget signal	~90 ads + Rs.2-4 Cr/mo after a ~70% marketing cut since 2022 = mid-tier scaler, leaner than Physics Wallah's Rs.5-10 Cr/mo.
Campaign structure	Exam-siloed; educator-led Advantage+ creative with limited concept testing and little topper-UGC injection.

2-5. CREATIVE / COPY / CRO / TRACKING SCORES

Creative Variety		3/10
UGC & Social Proof		3/10
Copy & Hook Strength		5/10
Landing Page CRO		5/10
Tracking & CAPI		4/10
Retargeting Depth		3/10

- **Creative leak:** Ads lean on educator/influencer talking-heads and 'Join for free' promos. Very few topper-AIR interviews, parent testimonials, or centre/franchise walkthroughs. Result-UGC is the one format Physics Wallah scales that Unacademy under-uses.

- **Copy leak:** Over-reliance on 'free class' / discount hooks ('Join for free', 'Unlimited access'). Missing angles: topper case study, failure-avoidance ('don't drop another year'), parent ROI, and post-merger trust ('now backed by upGrad').

- **Landing page leak:** Paid traffic lands on the generic unacademy.com hero. No course-specific landing pages, no topper result counts or reviews above the fold, a phone-OTP-only signup gate, and the app-install CTA competes with the subscription CTA.

- **Tracking leak:** Next.js SPA - pixel/GTM not verifiable on first paint (plain fetch is also blocked by bot protection). Post-merger, Unacademy and upGrad tags need consolidation to stop double-counting and duplicate retargeting. Retargeting appears one-size-fits-all, not exam-specific.

6. COMPETITOR BENCHMARK

Competitor	What they do better	Signal for Unacademy
Physics Wallah (listed, Nov 2025)	Scales topper-AIR result creatives + faculty UGC; ~Rs.5-10 Cr/mo Meta spend; growing revenue (Rs.2,887 Cr FY25).	PW took the creative lead in test prep; Unacademy's UGC gap is its single biggest creative opportunity.
Allen (offline)	Profitable, large-scale offline coaching; trust and results culture at centres.	Unacademy's franchise pivot must match offline trust signals in its ads.
Vedantu	Personalised landing pages per class/batch and topper video testimonials.	Unacademy's generic homepage burns ad traffic that Vedantu converts.
upGrad (new parent)	Higher-ed / working-professional brand with strong in-house performance + brand marketing.	Post-merger: consolidate tags and teams; pitch efficiency, not head-to-head.

7. 3 QUICK WINS (Implement in 7 Days)

WIN 1 - Creative: 15 Topper-Result UGC Reels + Post-Merger Trust Angle

Shoot 15 fifteen-second Reels: (a) recent JEE/NEET/UPSC toppers describing how Unacademy helped, (b) 5 parent testimonials, (c) 5 franchise-centre walkthroughs. Add a post-merger trust line ('now backed by upGrad'). Replace 30% of talking-head creatives. Expected: CTR +30-50%, CPA -15-25% within 10 days.

WIN 2 - CRO: Course-Specific Landing Pages + Fix the OTP-Only Gate

Route each exam ad to unacademy.com/goal/<jee> etc. with UTMs instead of the generic homepage. Add topper AIR counts + reviews + 'backed by upGrad' above the fold, a sticky 'Enroll' CTA, and an email signup option alongside OTP to cut drop-off. Expected: CVR +30-40%.

WIN 3 - Tracking: Server-Side CAPI + Post-Merger Tag Consolidation

Fire Meta Pixel + CAPI server-side on /signup, /subscribe and /pay. Consolidate Unacademy and upGrad pixels to stop double-counting after the acquisition. Build 3 retargeting audiences (visited goal page, started checkout, app-opened-not-subscribed) with exam-specific creatives. Expected: recapture 10-15% of dropped signups; cleaner attribution.

EXPECTED IMPACT

Metric	Current (est.)	After Wins	Impact
CTR (Meta)	0.9-1.2%	1.5-1.9%	+40-60%
Landing Page CVR	2.5-3.2%	4.0-5.0%	+40-50%
Cost Per Enrollment	Baseline = 100	70-80	-20-30%
Ad Spend Wastage	~30-40%	~15-20%	Saves Rs.60-90L/mo

READY TO PLUG THESE LEAKS?

Smart Pursuit will run a **14-day performance sprint** for Unacademy: Creative refresh, CRO rebuild of top landing pages, CAPI + retargeting setup. We work on a **performance-fee model** tied to conversion-cost reduction.

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